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WINTER STORM
PREPAREDNESS GUIDE

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Introduction

As I write this a historic winter storm is bearing down on much of the United States. The most recent estimate is that the storm (Winter Storm Fern) will affect 200-230 MILLION people throughout the country and, even worse, tens of millions of people are at risk of power outages, some of which could last more than a week.

We live in a society where people are used to being able to go out and buy anything the moment they need it. People aren't prepared to deal with the ramifications of not having power for a week.

You can't just go to the grocery store when the power is out. The power will likely be out there, too. And, even if the grocery store *has* power, the efficiency of the modern supply chain has allowed grocery stores to not have more than three days of product in the store at a time. Our systems rely on nothing getting in the way.

Well, it looks like a giant storm is about to get in the way.

If you aren't stocked up, it's time to focus on that. Hopefully this reaches you in time and you're able to get the critical stuff taking care of. And, what you're not able to get, now you'll have a better idea of what you should do before the next Winter Storm hits.

I pray you are able to push through the storm safely and that the Father gives you grace and peace as you're stuck inside the home.

UP-FRONT CHECKLIST

We'll do a quick checklist and then, below, we'll go into a more detailed explanation of each one.

Water is usually the first thing you need (and you'll see that in the list below) but as this is a Preparedness Guide specifically for winter storm which may knock your power out for a few days, I would prioritize the ability to stay warm over having water. We're going to focus on the Rule of 3s: You can survive 3 minutes without air; 3 days without water; and 3 weeks without food. Since you can make it 3 days without water; let's focus on not freezing to death.

HEAT

- Wear Layers
    - Inner layer should be synthetic or wool and not cotton.
- Create a microclimate that you can focus on keeping warm

WATER

- Bottled Water
- Fill pitchers
- If you're expecting an extended power outage, fill up the bath tub (they make bladders which fit in a tub if you can get ahold of one)

FOOD

- Canned Goods

LIGHTING

- Flashlights/Headlamps
- Electric Lanterns
- Candles & Flamed Lanterns (use fire if you NEED to but it's best to not have open flames in the house if you don't need to.

MEDICAL

- First Aid Kit
- 7+ Days of Prescriptions

Let's start with the most important things right up front. If you don't already have these things, you're going to want to try to get them right away.

The Rule of 3s says that the most important thing you need right now is WATER

WATER

You're going to need about 1 gallon of what per person, per day. If you have 2 people at your house and you're expecting to be without power or utilities for 3 days, you're going to need to store at least 6 gallons of water. FEMA suggests that you store at least 3 days of supplies so start there but nobody has ever felt overprepared if they have 2 weeks worth of supplies. So in that case, you'd need 28 gallons of water. Unless you've got a few extra 55 gallon container laying around you may want to...

Fill your bathtub up with water and then let the faucets drip so you have some water flow and your pipes don't freeze. Yeah, this probably means you're going to have use some wet wipes to bathe for a few days but that's better than dying of dehydration if the water stops running and you're not able to drink anything.

Speaking of drinking water, you're probably going to want to make sure you have a half decent water filter, or at least be able to boil the water. Speaking of boiling the water...

HEAT

Whether it's a cookstove or grill outside (though, I'm not sure you want to do that when it's below freezing), or a butane cooktop inside, you're going to want a way to boil water an/or warm some food up. Don't worry, we'll get to food in a minute. But probably a bigger reason for the heat is so you can stay warm and not freeze.

Layer Up
This may seem obvious but this one is a big deal. First of all, stay away from using cotton for your base layer. That stuff soaks up sweat and then it'll just cool you down. Try to put something synthetic or something wool on first and then use thicker layers as you build your way outward. Speaking of wool, don't forget that socks are a base layer, too. Use wool socks and not those white cotton jobs.

Pitch A Tent
This one may sound kinda weird but this is actually a really easy way to make a microclimate and not have to worry about heating up as much space. Put a tent up in whatever room you'd choose that doesn't have outside walls and can conserve the most heat. Put some sleeping bags in there and huddle close to loved ones.

Light My Fire

If you're lucky enough to have a fireplace in your home, take advantage of it. Make this the room that you use to pitch your tent. But, if you don't use your fireplace that often, make sure you open the flue. Remember that there are a couple of steps to this process.

Seal Up Windows and Doorways

If you have that cool tape you can buy on TikTok to seal cracks in doorways, now's the time to use it. There's special tape that you can use to seal around windows, but packing tape will work just fine. Do you have some plastic sheeting left over from that time you painted a room? Tape it over a window to keep the cold out.

FOOD

Non-Pershiables

You know what this is. Get some Canned Goods. Get some Mac & Cheese. Get some Ramen Noodles (maybe save this one for last). The typical 'Prepper' stuff is Rice & Beans. You can get some MREs but you're probably gonna want to get some stool softener, too.

One thing that may get overlooked if you're used to modern convenience may be a manual can opener. No power means no electric can opener.

LIGHT

Flashlights

I may be alone here but I have like 78 different flashlights in my house. Hopefully you have at least a few. Make sure they are charged or that you have some batteries for them. Speaking of batteries, go ahead an pick up some extra batteries.

Lanterns

There are a bunch of cool lanterns you can get these days that do a good job of lighting up a room. I have a battery powered Coleman camping lantern that takes so many D batteries that you may have to get a second mortgage on your house to make it work. There are much better options these days. There are even some that are inflatable and charge with solar. Only use the oil lanterns if you need to. There's no point in creating the fire hazard if you don't have to. Speaking of fire hazards, be extra vigilant when you're using anything with a flame. Fires happen much more frequently when the power goes out and people have to use flames and they're not used to it.

MEDICAL

First Aid Kit

Do you have a First Aid Kit? It's important to be able to treat the boo-boos that may happen during times like this. Bandages, ankle braces, burn treatment; you can be as careful as you want but sometimes unexpected things are going to happen. Be prepared.

Medication

If you're able, get refills on your prescriptions. You want to make sure you have enough meds to get you through the time you may not be able to get out of the house.

COMMUNITY

Check On Your Neighbors

Make sure they have a way to communicate with you if they have any issues. Exchange cell phone numbers if you haven't already. Do you have some walkie-talkies? See if they do and make sure you both know which channel you'll communicate on should there be a need.

Check on the Elderly

I'm getting old and I can tell you that we old folk get stubborn. Make sure they're doing ok. Offer to clear their sidewalks.